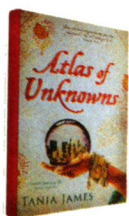


Life is ELSEWHERE

The first novel by Tania James limns an immigrant's life of ceaseless trade-offs



ATLAS OF UNKNOWNNS
by TANIA JAMES
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| By Rajni George |

The all Indian family saga never grows old—but it could bear with some reinvention. In *Atlas of Unknowns*, Linno and Anju Vallara share a frugal, sheltered life in Kumarakom until their world expands, in an epic tale of failings and deliverance. Raised by their father and grandmother after their mother dies mysteriously, the Syrian Catholic sisters begin to grow apart at 13 when Linno's hand is amputated after an accident. Linno drops out of school, apprenticing herself to art, while her sister excels at studies. Then comes the scholarship which takes Anju to New York, betraying Linno in a daring act of deception that estranges them even as it attempts to orchestrate the meteoric rise everyone hopes will take them all to the land her mother yearned to live in. This, then, is the central theme of *Atlas of Unknowns*: the life of trade-offs that is the immigrant's. For every step up comes sacrifice. As is the case when Anju's fabrications catch up with her and she runs away, going missing.

Here is another photogenic young Indian writer, glamorous a la Arundhati Roy, only her prose is more restrained than the latter's—both to its advantage and detriment. Sometimes it is contrived—"as illegal as a Cuban cigar and nowhere near as wanted"—but in other places it delights—"a medley of palms bends low, each falling in love with its likeness, while webs of light spangle the dark undersides of the leaves". Always, however, it is careful and spare, in that workshopped manner. The landscape is familiar—Alappat jewellery signs, Fancy Shoppes, banana leaves—as is the humid, sweaty drollery of everyday life in rural Kerala.



SAURABH SINGH

Till the point of Anju's demise, the tale is fairly gripping, if slow to catch. However, once all these elements are in play, the story seems to peter out. Ultimately, while the writing is pleasant enough to follow, the plot just doesn't have enough impact, though much follows. A troubled Linno uses her position as designer at an invitation card company to try to retrieve the Vallaras' prodigal daughter; meanwhile, in Jackson Heights, Anju hides from the Immigration and Naturalization Service as an assistant waxer at a beauty parlour. She has found a friend in lonely fellow immigrant Bird, who, she will never find out, was once in love with her mother Gracie. For the two were best friends, actresses in the Apsara Arts Club of

the '70s, an eccentric forbidden world of Malayali thespians that becomes part of a compelling but awkwardly forged subplot.

Other characters aren't as successful or appealing. Anju's host family, the Solankis, for example, are clunkily handled, as a sort of foil to the Vallaras: over-ambitious Mrs Solanki, superficial Mr Solanki and nerdy son Rohit who struggles to make something of his cultural inheritance, versus earnest dad Melvin, righteous Ammachi

and quietly self-sufficient Linno. Both families have sought the American dream, and both are in a way its victims, but the Solankis remain caricatures of prosperous NRIs. Their role at the end, as the emissaries of neo-colonial media interest in immigrants' lives, in particular, seems tacked on. Indeed, this tale is hurried along to an anticlimactic ending, weak even with the drama of a (predictable) buried secret.

A gifted storyteller who hasn't quite managed to transmute the riches she so clearly has in her possession, Tania James does shine, if at intervals, in this well-crafted yet uneven debut novel. ■